

people, I'm sure, are confused whether the Core i5 and i7 processors both use the same socket as the Core 2 range of processors.

Intel's all new Core i5 processors are soon going to be the mainstream processor and platform to go for, so my interest lies in the LGA1156 socket P55 chipset boards. Just to clarify, some of the high-end Core i7 processors can also be used on this socket so the socket isn't solely designed for Core i5.

We decided to look for motherboards as we had already made up our mind for the processor. The first shop we went to, had Gigabyte's P55M-UD2 board being shown to one of the other customers. It's one of the cheapest motherboards available if you're building a new rig. Priced at just Rs. 6,750, it seemed like a really good deal. We made a note of the price and model before moving on to the next models. The other interesting board that we see was the ASUS Maximus III Formula. This was a premium board from the Republic of Gamers lineup of boards from ASUS. It looked like a very fancy board with a huge heat sink and lots of red. The price wasn't worth it according to my friend.

While I was there, I figured I would look around for other boards and see what we could find for Intel's Core i7 and also the AMD processors. For the top of the line Core i7 processors, there isn't much of a choice. The X58 chipset is the only one available right now. While the ASUS Rampage II Extreme is the one of the sweetest boards to own, it is out of the reach of almost everyone. Few overclockers are going to be the customers of such products and for the rest, it's difficult to justify to yourself paying Rs. 24,950. The Biostar's Tpower X58 made more sense to my friend and so did the MSI X58M, a micro ATX board. He quickly made note of these prices, just in case he changed his mind and went Core i7. Both these models were around the Rs. 10,000 mark. Gigabyte's EX58-UD3R is only some Rs. 14,000 and the ATX version of the MSI X58M, the X58 PRO is also priced around the same.

For the slowly dying LGA775 socket, there are the largest number of motherboards and chipsets around. Intel's P45 chipset seems to be the most sensible one of the lot. ASUS' P5Q range of boards suites almost every kind of scenario. The cheapest board starts from around Rs. 8,500 and the most expensive model, the P5Q Premium ends at close to Rs. 20,000. Gigabyte's P45 range also has a good history and these are the two range of boards I found. I took down the prices in case anyone wanted to know. The cheapest model, the EP45-UD3L only costs Rs. 6,000 and is a very affordable board to build a good system on. For enthusiasts, Gigabyte's DQ6 version of the same